

DESK 42 - AUTOMATED BRANCH

Art Design Bible

A production-facing visual direction and Comfy ArtLab manual for a pixel-art bureaucracy factory whose defective decisions return as appeals.

pixel automation

alien claims

appeal feedback

solo-dev scope

Cream dossiers move forward. Red appeals move backward. The office chokes on what it officially decided.

Keep the identity. Replace the picture.

Survives

- Institutional green, paper cream and approval red.
- Hard pixel clusters, two shadow steps, upper-left light.
- Stamps, tubes, cabinets, CRTs and analog authority.
- Alien people treated as routine casework.
- Dry comedy produced by correct policy execution.

Retires

- Moths as identity or default species.
- One desk and a permanent card hand.
- Sanity, Fugue and arbitrary visual corruption.
- Combat, occult horror and decorative tentacles.
- Vertical tower composition and generic factory assemblers.

1

Floor

Bounded, lateral and contiguous.

6

Departments

Different verbs, not rainbow rooms.

2

Flows

Claims forward; appeals reverse.

0

Moths

The previous mascot is gone.

The old desk survives only as the five-minute manual opening and the final empty-desk image.



North-star frame: a single readable floor, visible queues, recognisable office machinery and a red appeal line physically contradicting the clean forward flow.

One projection, discrete zoom, no hidden art explosion

Locked view

- Fixed three-quarter orthographic camera.
- One quadrant; no building rotation.
- Camera-facing walls cut away consistently.
- Pan across a bounded floor.
- Branch, Operations and Inspection zoom steps.
- Integer-stable pixels; no fractional shimmer.

The floor should read like a circuit diagram made out of office furniture.

Native targets

Contract	Target
Logical canvas	384 x 216, 16:9
Floor diamond	32 x 16 px
Worker cell	about 32 x 48 px
Workstations	32-96 px footprints
UI icon master	32 x 32 px
1080p presentation	5x integer scale

Branch zoom

Routes, queues, department balance and expansion bays.

Operations zoom

Workers, machine cycles, dossier states and jams.

Inspection zoom

Policy cause, evidence trace and maintenance fault.

Paper is the payload. Green is authority. Red is consequence.



70% Base

Institutional green, paper and neutral structure. The world feels coherent before accents arrive.

20% Support

Dusty metal, wood, glass and material wear that describes actual use.

8% Task + 2% Impossible

Orange and red communicate work and consequence. Teal/magenta remain scarce.

Approved surfaces

- Painted steel with deliberate edge wear.
- Linoleum seams reinforcing the grid.
- Wire trays, paper, card, cloth files and twine.
- Bakelite keys and brass high-touch hardware.
- Dusty translucent tubes with steel collars.

Reject

- Glass-office minimalism.
- Warehouse belts as the default route.
- Neon cyberpunk and holograms.
- Uniform random scratches.
- Teal everywhere because aliens exist.

Six departments, six physical verbs

Intake - Separate

Fan trays, scanner apertures and many arrivals becoming one ordered line. Dusty blue glass and wire baskets.

Verification - Compare

Paired lightbeds, split shutters and contradiction needles. Amber light stays local to evidence.

Adjudication - Commit

The branch's strongest downward motion: heavy stamp press, sealed gate and restrained red at impact.

Archive - Retrieve

Visible capacity, index drums, mobile shelving and old information becoming physically harder to reach.

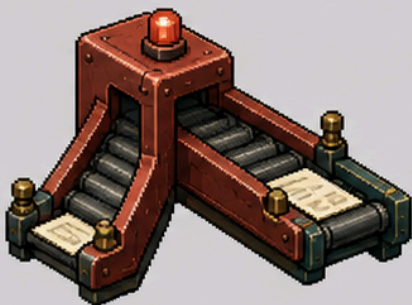
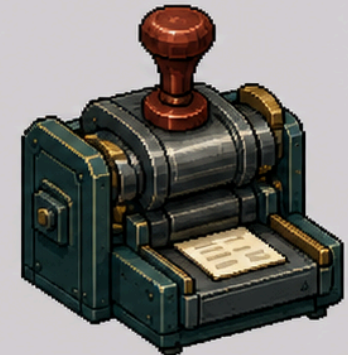
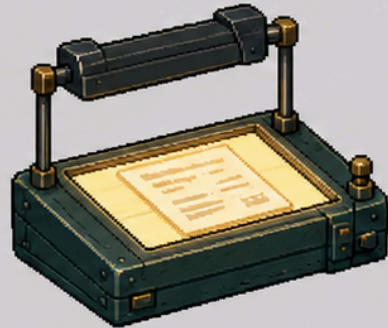
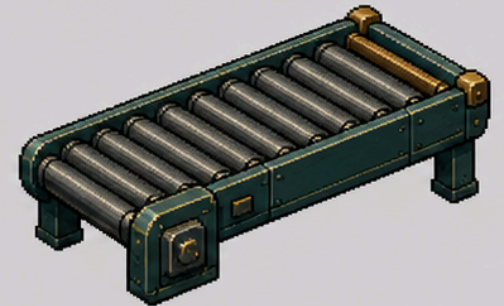
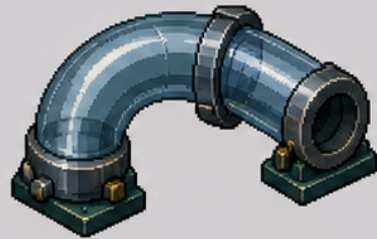
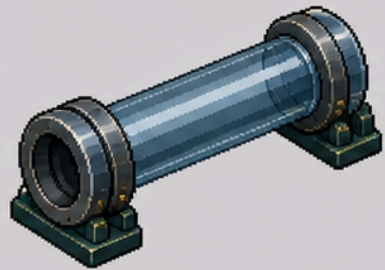
Legal - Loop

Reverse tubes, bound briefs, hearing clocks and locked bays for test cases. Error returns here.

Payroll - Pulse

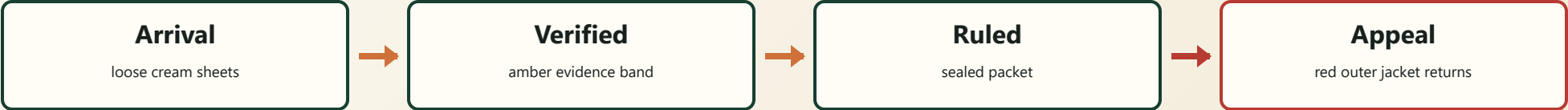
Punch clocks, rota wheels and predictable staff availability. Breaks are visible before they happen.

A department must remain recognisable in greyscale. Accent colour is the sixth cue, not the first.



Machine grammar: visible input, operation and output; office furniture pushed one step too far. These are concept candidates, not extracted runtime sprites.

The dossier is ore; the appeal is rework with standing



Dossier shape states

State	Visible change
Registered	blue corner tab and clip
Contradictory	misaligned bands and hard teal split
Held	orange clock tab projects from folder
Appeal	red jacket encloses original packet
Test case	red jacket plus brass lock clip

Congestion is physical

- Occupied buffer slots.
 - Folders leaning and compressing.
 - Raised output trays.
 - Staff detours and handoff waits.
 - Reverse tubes crossing clean flow.
 - Less clear floor around the bottleneck.
- Do not solve this with a red bar floating over the machine.

Players should be able to point at the decision that created the red folder now blocking Legal.



People, not mascots: employees read through role tools; alien anatomy is grounded by practical clothes, files and exhausted posture. Final sprites require authored model sheets and manual pixel redraw.

Readable workers; one impossible behaviour at a time

Staff silhouette hooks

Role	Tool/profile
Intake	forward tray or compact scanner
Verification	round loupe/headset and evidence board
Adjudication	heavy stamp tool, squared posture
Archive	file bundle or retrieval hook
Legal	bound brief and hearing clock
Payroll	rota drum or punch-card rack

Claimant principles

- One dominant body idea.
- Practical institutional clothing.
- Hands or equivalent controls remain legible.
- Emotion reads through posture, not mascot faces.
- No insects, moths, cult designs or combat stance.

Ordinary shell

An anomaly begins as a recognisable cabinet, copier, tube or clock.

One contradiction

It performs one impossible operation that can be explained in three beats.

Local colour

Teal marks the impossible boundary; magenta marks a rare collision.

Ordinary input - impossible operation - legible consequence.

The world shows throughput; UI explains causality

Persistent HUD
Day/time, Head Office objective, cash/reserve, backlog, appeal load and manual intervention. No cards or sanity.

Claim rail
Identity - evidence - confidence - policy - ruling - appeal history.

Machine inspector
Input queue - operation - output rule - staff coverage - exact fault.

Animation rhythm

receive

→

align

→

stamp

→

eject

Jams fail at the same point in the normal cycle. Appeals move against the branch's normal rhythm.

Audio handoff

Department	Signature
Intake	tray slide, scanner chirp
Verification	paper flip, relay, needle settle
Adjudication	stamp impact, latch
Legal	descending tube, clock, binder clamp
Payroll	punch clock, rota drum

A machine fault should sound like its normal rhythm becoming incomplete, not a generic alarm replacing it.

The proven prop route is structure first, appearance second



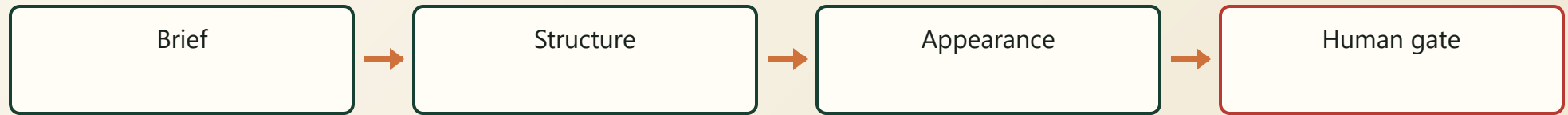
1. Blender owns geometry and camera.



2. Structural edge becomes ControlNet input.



3. Selected visual-development candidate.



What worked

Blender-guided SDXL ControlNet preserved filing-cabinet structure and produced repeatable candidate pixels. Contact sheets, manifests, validation and dry-run promotion exist.

What did not

Character identity-safe editing was not validated. The selected cabinet still needs native-grid redraw. Technical checks never make raw generated art shippable.

Reuse the proven pipeline; do not rebuild it from memory

Recovery source

Branch: codex/artlab-fast-assets
Commit: f871c307e98da1a6a638407a5c08793b95a05fbc

Raw output:
C:\Users\jacob\ComfyUI-Shared\output\Desk42\ArtLab

The current checkout contains only ignored cache files under ArtLab. Restore selectively before production.

Proven SDXL route

Checkpoint	Juggernaut-XL v9
Canvas	512 x 512
Sampler	DPM++ 2M / Karras
Steps / CFG	26 / 7.0
Control	0.85 strength, end 0.90
Pixel pass	128 area downscale, 28 colours, Bayer-4
Final proof	256 x 256 RGBA, still needs cleanup

Brief

Binary requirements and rejections.

Generate

Fixed seed family and structural controls.

Gate

Human semantic review at native scale.

Promote

Only refined, validated and provenance-complete art.

Blender owns shape. ComfyUI owns surface options. The human owns the final pixel asset.

Prompt the asset's job, not merely its mood

Shared style DNA

authored 2D pixel art for a bureaucratic automation management game,
fixed three-quarter orthographic view, institutional deep green and paper cream,
approval red limited to commitments and appeals, hard pixel clusters,
selective one-pixel outlines, two stepped shadows, upper-left fluorescent light,
controlled 28-colour palette, readable at native gameplay scale

Machine block

isolated modular workstation, clear input hopper,
visible central operation, readable output tray, service panel,
deep green painted steel, cream paper payload, brass high-touch fittings,
animation-ready silhouette, plain background, no labels

Universal negative

moth, insect, antennae, furry mascot, cult, occult rune,
combat, weapon, armor, dungeon, vertical tower, dollhouse skyscraper,
glossy sci-fi, hologram, neon cyberpunk, photorealism, painterly rendering,
soft gradient, bloom, random pixel noise, unreadable silhouette,
fake UI, readable text, logo, watermark, generated sprite sheet,
multiple camera angles, inconsistent scale

Every machine prompt states its input, operation, output, footprint and required runtime states.

First playable art is a machine kit, not a content catalogue

First playable ceiling

Floor/wall modules	12-16
Tube/conveyor modules	10-12
Core workstations	3, with 5-7 states each
Shared staff bodies	2 plus 3 role overlays
Claimant silhouettes	4
Dossier states	8-10
UI icons	16-24
Dressing props	12

Order of attack

- 1 **Flow proof**
Forward cream route and reverse red appeal route.
- 2 **Three stations**
Intake, Verification and Adjudication states.
- 3 **Shared people**
One body family, role tools and four claimants.
- 4 **ArtLab proof**
One prop through every gate and into Unity.

Week 1

Camera, grid, route kit and dossier sheet.

Weeks 2-3

Station states, staff and claimant model sheets.

Weeks 4-6

Restored pipeline, UI causality, appeal return and one anomaly.

A beautiful asset can still fail the game

Every asset must pass

Function	Input, operation and output are inferable.
Silhouette	Reads at gameplay scale and in greyscale.
State family	Idle, working and blocked differ structurally.
Camera/grid	Footprint, pivot and ports are exact.
Pixel craft	Intentional clusters; no filter noise.
Accessibility	Critical state has shape or motion support.
Provenance	Model, workflow, seed and edits recorded.
Unity test	Reads at Branch and Operations zoom.

Kill the direction if

- A route cannot be traced in one second.
- Departments need colour or labels to read.
- An appeal resembles ordinary red loot.
- Machines look like factory boxes wearing paper.
- Aliens look like collectible mascots.
- Complexity becomes visual noise before it becomes gameplay.
- AI correction costs more than direct pixel redraw.
- The final empty desk does not echo the built branch.

The first public-quality frame must show that the branch manufactured a bad decision and the decision has returned to demand processing.

The office should make an argument the player can watch.

**This arrived.
That department changed it.
This policy committed it.
That decision came back.
Now the machine is choking on
what it said.**



If the image only communicates "strange office," it is atmosphere. If it communicates the chain above, it is Desk 42.